

Write an interpretation for a chart

Activity · Visualizations & Interpretation · ~20 min

BEFORE YOU START

- ☐ You have at least one chart saved in your Visualisations folder
- ☐ The *Reading a viz* handout is next to you for the six-step framework

WHY IT MATTERS

A chart on its own is just a picture. The **interpretation text** is what turns it into something a decision-maker can act on.

What you'll do

Pick a chart, read it carefully, then write a three-part interpretation next to it on a slide. The interpretation is what a director will read, so each part has to earn its place.

The three-part structure

Part	What it does	Example
Title	The message in one sentence	<i>Northern Region ANC1 dropped 12% in Q1 2026 vs Q1 2025</i>
What you see	The chart in plain words: trends, magnitudes, anomalies. Facts only.	<i>Monthly volumes fell from ~8,500 to ~7,500, concentrated in three districts.</i>
What it means	The so-what. The action it would prompt.	<i>Supportive supervision visits in those three districts, plus a DQ check.</i>

The five steps

1 Pick a chart from your folder

Open the **Visualisations** tab and choose one of the charts you saved earlier. Pick one that shows movement (a trend, a drop, a regional contrast) — not a flat line. A flat chart is hard to write about and harder to act on.

2 Read the chart with the six-step framework

Before writing anything, walk through the chart using the *Reading a viz* framework. Talk it through with a teammate if you can:

1. What indicator is shown?
2. What level and period?
3. What is being compared (actual vs expected, districts, time)?
4. What are the values?
5. What stands out — trends, drops, spikes?
6. So what — what does this mean for service delivery?

Steps 1–5 give you the facts. Step 6 is your interpretation seed.

3 Write the title

Lead with the **message**, not a description. If a director read only the title, would they get the finding?

- Weak: *Coverage results*
- Strong: *Northern Region ANC1 dropped 12% in Q1 2026 vs Q1 2025*

4 Write "what you see"

Describe the chart in 1–3 sentences using your answers to steps 1–5. Numbers, trends, comparisons.

No interpretation yet — keep it to what is visible on the chart. The reader needs to trust your description before they trust your conclusion.

5 Write "what it means"

The so-what, drawn from step 6. **What action would this prompt?** Be specific. *"Supportive supervision visits in three districts, plus a check on the DQ scores for those facilities"* — not *"improve performance"*.

6 Add to your slide

In the Slide Decks tab, open your deck and add the chart. Place your three-part text alongside it. Save.

Pitfalls to avoid

- **Title as description** — *"Coverage results"* tells the reader nothing. Use the headline finding.
- **Mixing facts and interpretation** — keep "what you see" facts-only.
- **Vague action** — if the so-what does not name a person, place, or next step, rewrite it.

What's next

The next handout shows how the AI Assistant can draft this interpretation for you, and how to verify and refine what it gives you.